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Taika Waititi's Instagram crash out is a Trumpian sore loss

For all the horrible things Donald Trump has wrought upon the world — and there are so, so many — he's also taught us some important lessons. Trump is proof of several truths: A red-meat-and-stress-addled heart can withstand otherwise unthinkable conditions with the federal government's medical secrets; reality television ruined the world; and, if we're not careful, we're all liable to become parodies of ourselves one day, crying about it online.

That latter bit is certainly true for filmmaker Taika Waititi, whose otherwise tacky-yet-progressive veneer cracked last weekend when he took to Instagram to condemn the poor reviews of his latest film, "Klara and the Sun." After a torrent of bad press and worse box-office performance, the film's distributor, Sony, opted to scale back the movie's wide release, reducing the sci-fi dramedy's reach from 2,000 theaters nationwide to 800, most of which returned a meager profit. Never one to take his mediocrity on the chin, Waititi deflected the negativity outward, which, as we know, always paints someone in a good light!

Waititi's childish outburst is straight from the MAGA playbook. And while refuting film critics isn't akin to Donald Trump's most damning sins, Waititi's mockery is a symptom of a problem that won't be washed away by one blue wave, no matter how sizable.

Waititi reposted a graphic claiming that "Klara and the Sun" was "rebounding" with a 78% audience score on Rotten Tomatoes, a 53-point gap from the film's 25% critics score. (For what it's worth, neither number should ever be used to accurately measure a film's quality.) "I haven't read a review of anything aimed at me or my peers in 15 years," Waititi captioned the post. "But I do listen to the people . . . Let's spare a thought for those sad, lost souls who couldn't achieve their dreams of becoming artists, and thus settled, and became critics. Irrelevant. Out of touch. Obsolete. In the bin."

Reading Waititi's emoji-peppered caption, I was surprised to find it so carelessly evoked the Trumpian crybaby approach to social media. Whether on X or his own Truth Social, Trump's favorite way of addressing critics and opponents has long been to toss out adjectives at will. Tack a "SAD!" at the end of Waititi's caption, and it could easily pass for one of Trump's poetic musings. (If only Waititi had gone so far as to parrot my personal favorite Trump quip about Barney Frank by saying, "The critics looked disgusting, nipples protruding, in front of my movie. Very very disrespectful.")

Ironically, all those admonishments in Waititi's caption are also fitting descriptors for the state of Donald Trump's agenda, the one imitated by his legions of Republican cronies spread out across America, hoping to be elected in Tuesday's midterms. But judging by the results, MAGA's influence is waning fast. Seven Senate seats flipped, historically red states turned blue and a spate of monumental wins popped up nationwide. The MAGA bubble popped in real time. Americans have seen firsthand what little good fascist ideology does for the average, working-class person. And though the country may not become great again overnight, it appears the last 12 years of freefall have finally been suspended — at least for now.

Not to be all, "Oh, won't someone think of the celebrities?" about it, but such overwhelmingly

positive election results left me wondering what happens to someone like Waititi, whose childish outburst is straight from the MAGA playbook. For over a decade, Trump has used social media to peddle broadly disparaging, dangerous rhetoric that has legitimate impact outside the phone screen. The reckless hatred comprising MAGA ideology is so potent that it's bled into the ways even otherwise progressive people wield their power, like crude oil painting an ocean black. And while refuting film critics isn't akin to Trump's most damning sins, Waititi's mockery is a symptom of a problem that won't be washed away by one blue wave, no matter how sizable.

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One would think that Waititi would know better. For one, the guy is 51 years old, certainly experienced and well-established enough to let a flop roll off his back. How fitting that his biggest success is the anti-fascist yet aesthetically tasteless political satire, "Jojo Rabbit," which won the Oscar for best adapted screenplay in 2020, just as the Trump era was revving up for its second leg. That film, about a 10-year-old Hitler Youth who begins to grapple with the realities of life in 1940s Germany, examines propaganda's influence and the power of hegemony, even if it often lacks the nuance and perspective such a satire warrants. For better, or more often, for worse, Waititi's writing displays a self-possessed vulgarity that gets in the way of his more salient observations. Case in point: It's downright ludicrous to stake your name on a film renouncing hate, then take aim at critics — people not exactly matched in influence to someone like Waititi — just six years later.

But this is the rot that social media creates. Whether it's Instagram, X, TikTok, or YouTube, these sites have incentivized and monetized incendiary opinions. Their algorithms push small people into major power. What was designed to ostensibly be a great equalizer has only divided the world more, making animosity easily accessible to anyone who gets their rocks off on sewing discourse through cruelty.

For some time now, arts critics have been easy targets on these platforms. Gone are the days of the critic playing dilettante, having intellectual conversations over martinis and cigarettes at the month's salon for like-minded individuals. To be a critic today — to pursue one's passion for art and writing and learning, all rolled into one — is to subject oneself to a pretty bleak existence. In most cases, the pay is meager. The hours are long. The job is demanding. And virtually no one has the patience or attention span to read an entire article anymore, let alone engage with its ideas. A legitimate critic doesn't stumble into the job just to point and laugh; they write because they have real passion for what they cover. Surely someone like Waititi would say the same when he begins a new project after a string of flops.

If living in MAGA-world for a decade has taught us anything, it's that things aren't just good because one person says so. Uniformity is the enemy of art, and blind trust is the scourge of politics. There is no future without recognizing the subtleties existing between the lines.

What Waititi fails to realize is that he's not punching up or down, but laterally. This is artist versus artist. If the context is right, a good piece of criticism can be as life-altering as a good film. But that's

hard to see when the internet has built such a wide chasm between people, reducing the impact of writing in favor of scrolling. Along with social media's effect on human behavior, it's had a heavy hand in blunting the journalism industry. If everyone's a critic, then no one is, and that's precisely why monitoring Rotten Tomatoes scores like they're poll numbers is futile and ridiculous.

But it's not just Waititi who's vulnerable to this unique form of MAGA-tinged, social media-brained psychosis; critics can fall prey to it, too. Whether it's a filmmaker, a film critic, or just your average filmgoer, social media has confined us all to its machine. No one is exempt from consumer tech's sway. And if a writer or filmmaker wants to make a splash, tossing out an inflammatory opinion aimed at a peer is a surefire shortcut. I've seen this affect critics' prose over time, with certain writers (or their outlets) favoring button-pushing pull quotes and headlines for attention. But in most cases, no critic is happy to spend two hours watching something they find insufferable. No matter how gleeful Siskel and Ebert used to look sparring over movies, their industry was built on intellectual debate in pursuit of cinematic resonance, not schadenfreude.

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What's most concerning in Waititi's response is his foul self-importance, which is the real stain of MAGA politics. While an artist should avoid burdening themselves with hypothetical responses to their work before it's even out in the world, considering the eventual reaction is worthwhile. Engaging with other people's perceptions is a practice we could all stand to do with more grace and tact. Contemplating a differing opinion shows maturity and humility, not absolute agreement. Pointing a finger won't do anything for a person's growth, artistic or otherwise. America's politicians are only just beginning to relearn that lesson, understanding the value in trying to address problems, rather than gesture toward them with a shrug.

If America's blue wave is indeed going to usher in a new era where politicians actually act in favor of the people, and Trumpian artists like Waititi make themselves look foolish on Mark Zuckerberg's Instagram, we owe some props to one of the century's most prolific liberals. Aaron Sorkin's "The Social Reckoning" actually got a few things right. In last month's companion piece to "The Social Network," Sorkin posited that the average American would soon be mobilized by their fatigue with MAGA politics and social media. But his director's eye lacked style and discernment. Sorkin responded to criticisms with pleasant diplomacy, even questioning his own merits as a director versus a screenwriter. "I'm worried that the parts of directing that I'm not good at are those parts you can't learn," he admitted.

While there may be truth to his concern, Sorkin's introspection is precisely the kind of pause this country could learn from. If living in MAGA-world for a decade has taught us anything, it's that things aren't just good because one person says so. Uniformity is the enemy of art, and blind trust is the scourge of politics. There is no future without recognizing the subtleties existing between the lines. The only thing that is, to quote Waititi, irrelevant, out of touch and obsolete is the arrogance in thinking anyone could know it all.

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